The US was not particularly eager to spring to Tibet's defense. Acheson had wanted to use the threat to Tibet to convince India to move away from its "unrealism [and] semi-detached attitude" toward the Chinese challenge.[155] But the US had had no desire to become embroiled alone (i.e., without India and/or the UK) by holding out the prospect of aid to Tibet. Henderson had clarified to K. P. S. Menon that the US did not want to provoke a Chinese invasion or make it harder for the Indian government to persuade Tibetan officials to accept autonomy.[156] Subsequently, Washington had looked for signs of change in India's attitude and solicited Delhi's views on potential US-UK-Indian coordination to meet Tibet's defense requirements. But for Acheson, ideally India had to "bear primary responsibility."[157]

Delhi, on its part, had continued to eschew any covert or overt actions that Beijing might see as provocative or as part of a joint US-India effort to counter China.[158] Officials did not believe that India could offer effective resistance because of Tibet's inaccessibility and Delhi's limited resources. There were also serious doubts about Tibetan willingness to resist. Thus the Indian government had encouraged Tibetan officials to negotiate with China.[159]

The outbreak of the war in Korea had increased American interest in supporting Tibet. While clarifying that assistance would not extend to direct involvement if China invaded Tibet, US officials had suggested that Tibetan officials ask India to facilitate American aid.[160] But the war had not made India any more likely to help. Nehru did not think it could deter a Chinese invasion of Tibet, though officials had tried to delay it.[161] They had pursued the issue on "firm [but] friendly lines" in Beijing. Bajpai had given the British high commissioner and Henderson the gist of India's message to China: that India had gone out of its way to establish friendly relations with China even though this had been detrimental to its other bilateral relations; a Chinese invasion of Tibet might make India reassess its view of Chinese intentions, as well as its support for Beijing's entry into the UN.[162]

After the invasion in October 1950, Henderson blamed India, believing that Tibet had "lost heart" because of Delhi's reticence.[163] Nonetheless, while urging India to do more and offering to be helpful, Acheson did not want to pressure India lest Delhi blame Washington for any consequent Sino-Indian complications. He did hope that, along with Chinese "duplicity